

EDM 101 – Ethics and Patients' Rights in Dental Medicine

Lecture 5

Dentist and Colleagues / Employee Relationship Rights

Dr. Barzi Barzan M Fadhil

BDS, MSc, Advanced Aesthetic Restorative Dentistry



barzi.barzan@auis.edu.krd



Drbarzibarzan



AMERICAN UNIVERSITY OF IRAQ, SULAIMANI

زانكۆی ئەمریکی له عێراق، سلێمانی | الجامعة الأمريكية في العراق، السليمانية

This classes learning outcomes

By the end of this lecture you are able to

- Describe the ethical responsibilities of dentists toward colleagues and dental staff.
- Identify unethical behaviors in professional relationships (e.g., fee-splitting, patient attraction).
- Explain how teamwork and conflict resolution contribute to safe and ethical patient care.



Dentistry is not practiced alone.

Dentists work with:

- A. Other dentists
- B. Specialists
- C. Dental assistants
- D. Hygienists
- E. Laboratory technicians
- F. Physicians and pharmacists



Dental Ethics Beyond the Patient

Dental ethics includes duties toward:

- A. Patients
- B. Colleagues
- C. Society

Ethical behavior must be consistent in all professional relationships.



Core Ethical Principles Applied to Professional Relationships

Autonomy – Respect professional judgment

Beneficence – Work together for patient benefit

Non-maleficence – Avoid harming patients through ego or competition

Justice – Fair treatment of colleagues

Veracity – Honesty in communication



Respect Among Dentists

Dentists must:

- Treat colleagues with dignity
- Avoid public criticism
- Communicate professionally
- Focus on patient welfare

Professional disagreement is acceptable.

Professional disrespect is not.



Referral Ethics

1. The case exceeds their competence
2. Specialized skills are required
3. Patient safety is at risk

Referral must be based on patient benefit, not financial advantage.



Unethical Referral Practices

Two major unethical behaviors:

1. Fee-splitting
 - A. Receiving money for referring patients
 - B. Violates justice and beneficence
2. Attracting patients from colleagues
 - A. Undermining another dentist
 - B. Using negative comments to gain patients



Managing Previous Faulty Treatment

If you see poor work from another dentist:

1. Avoid harsh criticism
2. Do not speculate
3. Focus on current patient care
4. Explain objectively

Professional integrity requires discretion



Dentist and Employee Relationship

The dentist is:

- A. The leader of the dental team
- B. Legally responsible for patient care
- C. Responsible for supervision

The staff must work within their scope.



Scope of Practice of Dental Assistants

Dental assistants:

- Can not diagnose
- Can not establish fees
- Can not judge treatment quality
- Must follow the dentists supervision



Teamwork in Dentistry

Effective dental teams require:

- A. Communication
- B. Defined responsibilities
- C. Mutual respect
- D. Shared goal: best patient care

Poor teamwork increases the risk of errors.



Leadership Responsibility

- A. Maintain a safe environment
- B. Ensure equipment readiness
- C. Supervise infection control
- D. Take ultimate responsibility



Self-Regulation of Dentistry

Dentistry is a self-regulating profession.

Society grants:

1. Trust
2. Privileges
3. Autonomy

In return, the profession must maintain high ethical standards.



Reporting Unsafe or Unethical Behavior

- Recognize unsafe practices
- Avoid silent complicity
- Follow institutional reporting procedures

Protecting patients is more important than protecting colleagues.



Conflict Resolution

- A. Understand communication styles
- B. Focus on the issue, not the person
- C. Address problems early
- D. Be patient and professional



The Code of Ethics and Ethical Principals

Ethical Codes	Ethical Principle
No fee-splitting	Justice & Beneficence
No false advertising	Veracity
Refer when beyond competence	Non-maleficence
Maintain confidentiality	Autonomy & Respect



The ADA Code translates moral principles into enforceable professional standards.

Principle	Meaning	Example Rule
Autonomy	Respect choices	Obtain informed consent
Non-maleficence	Do no harm	Refer beyond competence
Beneficence	Promote welfare	Provide emergency care
Justice	Be fair	No fee-splitting
Veracity	Be honest	No false advertising



Summary;

- A. Respect colleagues
- B. Refer appropriately
- C. Avoid financial conflicts
- D. Supervise staff responsibly
- E. Promote teamwork
- F. Maintain professional integrity



Thank You!



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